Pakistani leaders believed reduced the likelihood of large-scale Indian retaliation. In the absence of this capability, they probably would not have been willing to adopt such an aggressive policy in Kashmir. The 1990 crisis thus does not demonstrate nuclear weapons' stabilizing effects on the South Asian security environment. Rather, the standoff shows that nuclear weapons destabilized the subcontinent almost as soon as India and Pakistan began to acquire them.

ooooo

In the next section, we discuss nuclear weapons' effects on South Asia between 1998 and 2002. Ganguly argues that the 1999 Kargil crisis stemmed from a long-standing Pakistani plan to launch a "limited probe" and possibly present India with a fait accompli. The choice of the Kargil region was hardly accidental. Even though India could be expected to tenaciously defend against any incursion across the line of control, a Pakistani probe in this region did not threaten any fundamental Indian interests or military assets.

Kapur maintains that between 1998 and 2002 nuclear weapons continued to destabilize the region in much the same manner as they had previously. Indeed, in the wake of the 1998 nuclear tests, an overt nuclear weapons capacity emboldened the Pakistanis to behave even more provocatively than before, triggering the most serious Indo-Pakistani conflict in decades. This was soon followed by another major militarized standoff that brought the two sides to the brink of large-scale war.

NUCLEAR WEAPONS IN SOUTH ASIA, 1998–2002

In the years following the 1990 crisis, militant violence, supported by Pakistani arms, funds, and training, continued to wrack Indian Kashmir. Another large-scale Indo-Pakistani confrontation did not occur, however, until after the two countries' 1998 nuclear tests—an event that many observers expected would stabilize Indo-Pakistani relations.